Conversation — track 1, 3, 4

Khai wants to open a café near a university. He asks his friend Freya, who runs a bakery, for feedback.

Khai: OK, be honest. What do you think of my café plan?

Freya: Well, I love the idea. **It might be a bit** ambitious, though.

Khai: Ambitious? In what way?

Freya: Ninety seats **seems like quite a lot** for your first café. **Perhaps you could** start smaller?

Khai: Point taken. What about the prices? Don't hold back.

Freya: They're **possibly a touch** on the high side for a student area.

Khai: So basically, you think it's a terrible idea.

Freya: Not at all! **I'd just** tweak a few things. And I'll be your first customer.

Speak Like a Native — track 2

1. It might be a bit ambitious, though.

weak: "a bit"
linking: "bit‿ambitious"
strong: "ambitious"

"bit ambitious" nối thành "bi-tam-bi-shợs"; giọng Anh giữ /t/ rõ. "though" cuối câu xuống rồi hơi lên: lời chê nghe mềm hẳn.

2. Ninety seats seems like quite a lot for your first café.

linking: "quite‿a‿lot"
weak: "for your"
strong: "Ninety", "first"

Giọng Anh giữ /t/ rõ: "Ninety" /ˈnaɪnti/ "nai-nti", "quite a lot" nối thành "quai-tơ-lot". Giọng Mỹ hay đọc "nai-ni", "quai-đơ-lat".

3. Not at all! I'd just tweak a few things.

linking: "Not‿at‿all"
change: "just tweak" (hai âm t gộp làm một)
strong: "all", "few"

"Not at all" nối thành "no-tơ-tôl" (giọng Mỹ: "na-đơ-đal"). Trong "just tweak", hai âm /t/ gộp làm một: "jớs-twik".

• Từ rào đón (a bit, possibly, perhaps) đọc nhẹ, không nhấn; nhấn vào ý chính: a bit AMBITIOUS.
• Lời góp ý kết thúc bằng "though" hoặc câu hỏi (Perhaps you could…?) thường xuống rồi hơi lên: nghe mềm, không áp đặt.
• Giọng Anh (Freya) giữ /t/ rõ giữa hai nguyên âm: not at all → "no-tơ-tôl"; giọng Mỹ (Khai) đọc thành "d" nhẹ.

Role Play — track 6

A: OK, be honest. What do you think of my café plan?

B: Well, I love the idea. It might be _____, though.

A: Ambitious? In what way?

B: Ninety seats seems like quite a lot for your first café. Perhaps you could _____?

A: Point taken. What about the prices? Don't hold back.

B: They're possibly a touch on the high side for a student area.

A: So basically, you think it's a terrible idea.

B: Not at all! I'd just _____. And I'll be your first customer.

Study Notes

Don't hold back.
Cứ nói thẳng đi, đừng ngại.
Dùng khi muốn người kia góp ý thật lòng, kể cả điều khó nghe. "hold back" là kìm lại, không nói hết.
Cách nói tương đương: Give it to me straight.

They're possibly a touch on the high side for a student area.
Giá có lẽ hơi cao một chút so với khu sinh viên.
"on the high side" là hơi cao; "a touch" (kiểu Anh) là một chút. Cả hai làm lời chê nhẹ đi nhiều.
Cách nói tương đương: They might be a little high for students.

Grammar Focus

Nói giảm: might / seem / a bit / slightly

Thêm từ rào đón để lời nhận xét bớt nặng nề: dùng might, could thay cho is; seem thay cho be; thêm a bit, slightly, a little trước tính từ.

The plan **might be a bit** risky.
This soup **seems slightly** salty to me.
Your speech **could be a little** shorter.

Góp ý mềm mỏng: Perhaps you could… / I'd just… / I wonder if…

Đưa lời khuyên như một gợi ý, không phải mệnh lệnh. "I'd + V" nghĩa là "nếu là tôi thì tôi sẽ…"; "I wonder if…" rất lịch sự.

Perhaps you could ask your manager first?
I'd just change the title a little.
I wonder if a bigger font **might** help.

Substitution Drill — track 7

1. It might be a bit ambitious, though.
   a. slightly risky
   b. a little expensive
   c. a tad optimistic

2. Perhaps you could start smaller?
   a. open with fifty seats
   b. rent a smaller place
   c. test the idea first

3. I'd just tweak a few things.
   a. rethink the location
   b. shorten the menu a little
   c. lower the prices slightly